night of 15 January 1991, the Gulf War broke out between Iraq and the Al ied Forces led by the USA. In one stroke, thanks to satel ite television invading Indian skies by that time, rockets and missiles captured the imagination of the entire nation. People started discussing Scuds and Patriots in coffee houses and tea shops. Children began flying paper kites shaped like missiles, and playing war games along the lines of what they saw on American television networks. The successful test firing of Prithvi and Trishul during the course of the Gulf War was enough to make an anxious nation relax. The newspaper reports of the programmable trajectory capability of the Prithvi and Trishul guidance system, using microwave frequencies in virtual y unjammable bands, created widespread awareness. The nation was quick to draw paral els between the missiles operational in the Gulf War and our own warhead carriers. A common query I encountered was whether Prithvi was superior to a Scud, whether Akash